PRE-PURCHASE INSPECTION CHECKLIST

Toyota 4Runner 3rd Gen

1996–2002 · N180 · 5VZ-FE · 3RZ-FE

BOXYTRUCKS

CHECK BEFORE YOU BUY

- [ ] **Frame rust, properly**
  Crawl under it. Forum members flag the crossmember-to-frame welds, the rear lower control arm mounts, the triangular trailing-arm brackets, the area behind the axle where the spare hangs, and the rocker ends. Probe with a screwdriver: a hole or two is fixable, a frame thin from end to end is not.

- [ ] **Lower ball joints**
  The stock LBJ is the 3rd gen's famous weak link — if it lets go the control arm drops and the wheel folds under. 2001–02 trucks were covered by Toyota safety recall 50J (NHTSA 05V-225), which replaced the lower ball joints; on any year, ask what was fitted. AdventureTaco's advice is OEM Toyota only.

- [ ] **Timing belt records**
  The V6 wants a belt at roughly 90,000-mile intervals, ideally with the water pump and thermostat. It's a non-interference engine, so a failure is usually a tow, not a rebuild — but no paperwork means budget for the job.

- [ ] **Rear axle seals and brakes**
  Blown rear axle seals are a known 3rd gen habit; gear oil then soaks the drum brake shoes and washes out the wheel bearing. Look for wet backing plates and listen for a bearing growl on the test drive.

- [ ] **Locker and 4WD function**
  If it's a 1996–2000 4WD with the E-locker, make sure it actually engages (it's meant for 4Lo and low speed). On Multi-Mode trucks, cycle every mode. 2001–02 trucks have no factory rear locker regardless of what the ad says.

- [ ] **Steering slop**
  Wandering or a clunk over bumps often points to worn steering rack bushings (common around 100k miles) or tie-rod ends. Both are cheap to fix but useful bargaining chips.

- [ ] **Recalls and readiness**
  1996–98 trucks are covered by NHTSA recall 02V-021 (Toyota campaign 20A), under which dealers replaced rear suspension parts; ask whether it was done. And plug in a scanner — IH8MUD members warn about sellers clearing codes to hide a dead catalytic converter, so check all readiness monitors are complete.

- [ ] **Who lifted it?**
  A tidy lift with known parts is a bonus; a mystery spacer lift with no alignment records is a project. Forum veterans' advice is blunt: skip a lifted truck unless the lift was done properly.

YEARS TO KNOW

1999	SWEET SPOT	Facelift ('fat lip' bumper, multi-parabola headlights), new dash; optional Multi-Mode transfer case. IH8MUD regulars rate 1999–2000 the best years, a '99 with the E-locker

		above all
2000	SWEET SPOT	Manual gearbox dropped (last manual 4Runner); rear e-locker still optional. The other half of the forum-favourite 1999–2000 pair

RECALLS TO ASK ABOUT

- ☐ **Missing utility-vehicle warning label**
  1996 · NHTSA 96V-098
- ☐ **Stability under heavy load and severe steering**
  1996–1998 · NHTSA 02V-021
- ☐ **Front lower ball joints**
  2001–2002 · NHTSA 05V-225

IS IT THE REAL THING?

- ☐ **Model codes**
  US trucks are RZN180/185 (2.7 3RZ-FE four) or VZN180/185 (3.4 5VZ-FE V6). KZN185 and KDN185 are Japanese diesel Hilux Surfs.
- ☐ **Rear e-locker**
  Optional on 4WD trucks from 1996 to 2000, never standard on any trim per a 1997 brochure cited by owners, and gone for 2001–02. Look for the dash switch, the actuator and wiring on the rear diff, and the factory locker placard. A locked rear diff also takes more oil: 2.75 L vs 2.45 L.
- ☐ **Facelift tells**
  1999–2000 trucks have the 'fat lip' bumper and multi-parabola headlamps; 2001–02 add clear tail lamps, a new grille and five-spoke wheels; 2002 adds chrome liftgate trim.
- ☐ **Transfer case**
  1996–98 4WD trucks use a part-time lever (Limiteds use a pushbutton for H4); Multi-Mode was optional from 1999 and standard on 4WD from 2001.

NOTES

From the full guide at https://boxytrucks.com/models/4runner/3rd-gen/, with sources. Recalls follow the VIN: check at nhtsa.gov/recalls. General information only, not a professional inspection; see boxytrucks.com/about/disclaimer/. © BoxyTrucks